

# Daksh Walia

*Predoctoral Researcher in Economics, University of Oxford*  
*Incoming PhD in Economics, MIT (2027)*

+91 9878137741  
✉ dakshwl@outlook.com

## Research Interests

My research interests lie in development, environmental, and labor economics. Currently, I am working on research projects relating to sexual harassment in firms, refugee integration in developing countries, legislative determinants of female labor demand, and exploring the role of AI in jobseeking markets and match quality. I am generally interested in studying social protection program design to achieve socioeconomic goals like climate resilience; and in understanding frictions that prevent workers and firms from maximizing their productivity.

## Education

- Starting Aug 2027 **PhD in Economics**, *Massachusetts Institute of Technology*, Cambridge, MA, USA  
Deferred start of program to August 2027.
- Sep 2023 – **M.Phil in Economics (Distinction)**, *University of Oxford*, Oxford, UK  
Jun 2025 MPhil in Economics, affiliated with Merton College, and supported by the Rhodes Scholarship. Distinctions in overall score, thesis, a machine learning option course, as well as advanced doctoral-level coursework in Microeconomics, Econometrics, and Empirical Research Methods.
- Aug 2021 – **M.A. in Economics (GPA: 3.94/4)**, *Ashoka University*, Sonipat, India  
May 2023 Summa Cum Laude, Dean's List in all semesters, highest aggregate GPA in cohort.
- Aug 2018 – **B.A. (Hons.) in Economics (GPA: 3.97/4)**, *Ashoka University*, Sonipat, India  
May 2021 Summa Cum Laude, highest aggregate GPA in cohort, and Economics Department Award for Academic Excellence in BA Economics.
- GRE (2022) 170/170 in Quantitative Reasoning, 170/170 in Verbal Reasoning, 6/6 in Analytical Writing

## Awards and Scholarships

- Rhodes Scholar 2023** *Rhodes Trust, United Kingdom*: Selected as one of five **Rhodes Scholars** from the India Constituency for 2023, to pursue graduate studies at the University of Oxford.
- Stiglitz Essay Prize (First Prize)** *International Economics Association*: Wrote a research-based essay "*The Meritocratic Myth*" on the causes and policy implications of inequality; awarded the first prize in the undergraduate category at IEA's 2021 World Conference.
- National Bal Shree Award** Awarded the National Bal Shree Award for Creative Writing by the Ministry of Human Resource Development, India.

## Research

- Ongoing **Refugee and Host Integration through the Safety Net: Impact Evaluation in Ethiopia**  
Joint work with Dennis Egger (Oxford), Alfredo Manfredini-Böhm (TBIGC), Belay Mohammed (Oxford), and Sandra Rozo (World Bank). Evaluating the economic and social cohesion effects of a unique program to integrate refugees and hosts through a combination of public works participation and a large livelihoods grant. We estimate the effects of cross-randomized out-group social exposure through direct contact or higher community-level saturation of direct contact, and model how diffusion of prejudices affects connection formation in social networks.

- Ongoing **Firm responses to legislation on handling sexual harassment**  
Upcoming project with Sonia Bhalotra (University of Warwick), Kanika Mahajan (Ashoka University), Fan Wang (Houston) and Medha Chatterjee (UC Davis) focusing on modeling the distortionary effects of sexual harassment on gender composition in firms, and the productivity losses generated as a consequence. We also evaluate the unintended effects of legislation in India aimed at preventing workplace sexual harassment on female employment in firms, and calibrate the model to firm-level data to carry out counterfactual policy simulations.
- Ongoing **The Impact of Legislative Changes on Female Employment in Firms**  
Joint work with Bhanu Gupta (Ashoka), Kanika Mahajan (Ashoka), and Anisha Sharma (Ashoka) studying the effect of Indian states changing discriminatory legislation that prevented women from working night shifts in factories. The removal of a constraint on demand for women's labour increases the share of women workers in firms, but only in large firms that can absorb the costs associated with hiring women in night shifts.
- Ongoing **The Role of Economic Inclusion Programs in Mediating Climate Shocks**  
MPhil thesis at Oxford on the interaction between a nation-wide poverty graduation program in Ethiopia and climate shocks in the form of persistent droughts, evaluating how social protection programs can act as vehicles for assisting climate resilient adaptation in developing countries. Awarded a distinction.
- Scottish **Measuring Workplace Sexual Harassment: A Review**  
Journal of Political Economy, 2025  
Review paper with Abi Adams (Northwestern University) on the measurement of sexual harassment in economics and other disciplines, and the relative estimates of prevalence that different measurement approaches produce to understand framing that generates more reliable and consistent estimates while being succinct enough for large-scale data collection.
- Journal of Population Economics, 2024 **An Indian Enigma? Labour market impacts of the world's largest livelihoods program**  
Paper with Ashwini Deshpande (Ashoka University) and Shantanu Khanna (Northeastern University) studying the impact of increased enrolment in self-help groups within Indian districts on rural female labour force participation in India and reallocation of labour from casual work to self-employment.
- Markets and Organizations **Policy Paper on Financing the Recovery from COVID-19**  
Wrote a research paper with Dr. Arvind Ashta (Burgundy School of Business) on the possible taxation and funding channels of financing the recovery from COVID-19.

---

## Presentations

- 2025 **ASSA Annual Meeting, San Francisco, USA**  
2024 **Bristol Applied Economics Meeting, University of Bristol**

---

## Economics Work Experience

- Aug 2025 – July 2027 **Predoctoral Research Fellow in Economics, Oxford Centre for Macro-Experimental Development, Centre for Study of African Economies**
- Working on a large scale RCT evaluating high frequency general equilibrium effect of large cash transfers in Malawi with Dennis Egger, John Walker, Winnie Mughogho, and Tilman Graff.
  - *Fieldwork*: Survey design, enumerator training, SurveyCTO coding, and data quality checks for 9 large scale household and enterprise surveys.
  - *Analysis*: Creating data processing pipeline, preparing slides for academic and policy presentations, assisting with sampling.

- Jul 2024 – **Research Assistant**, *World Bank and University of Oxford*
- Jun 2025 ○ Working for Dr. Dennis Egger (Oxford) and Gashaw Abate (WB), John Loeser (WB), and Margaux Vinez (WB) on the evaluation of a graduation program rolled out under Ethiopia's economic inclusion program 'Productive Safety Net Program' to understand the effects of large credit and grant on local economies.
- Responsible for high frequency checks for data collection, as well as cleaning, processing, and analysing data to estimate treatment effects on targeted households as well as spillovers on other households and markets.
- May 2022 – **Research Assistant**, *Dr. Kanika Mahajan, Ashoka University*
- Sep 2023 ○ Gained experience working with big data by cleaning and processing a large, proprietary dataset on job postings in India using STATA and Python, utilizing High-Performance Computing nodes.
- Studied the impacts of foreign visa policy changes on domestic labour markets using an event study framework. Worked on analysing firm responses to policy changes to understand the effect on demand for female workers.
- Dec 2023 **Research Assistant**, *Dr. Severine Toussaert, University of Oxford, Oxford, UK*
- Short project working on text analysis for a project analysing decision making processes in research teams.
- Sep 2021 – **Research Assistant**, *Dr. Ashwini Deshpande & Dr. Shantanu Khanna*
- May 2022 ○ Acquired data for labour outcomes from government datasets, self-help group participation data from the web, and then worked on data cleaning, processing, and analysis using R and STATA.
- Mar 2023 – **Research Assistant**, *Dr. Yatish Arya, Ashoka University*
- Aug 2023 ○ Worked on projects pertaining to the voting effects of newspaper closures in America and the role of political messaging in manufacturing salience of events in voting decisions in Indian elections.
- Jun 2022 – **Research Intern**, *Good Business Labs, Bengaluru, India*
- Aug 2022 ○ Conducted an extensive literature review and assisted the intervention designing for a climate action related RCT study aimed at improving energy efficiency in Indian Micro Enterprises.
- Assisted with data cleaning, processing, and analysis for an RCT study on the effects of financial and digital literacy interventions amongst adolescent girls in Jharkhand.
- Aug 2022 **Teaching Assistant**, *QuantEcon Workshop India*
- Teaching Assistant for the India edition of the QuantEcon Workshop conducted by Professor Thomas J. Sargent of New York University to teach Python programming for economics.
- Jun 2020 – **Data Intern**, *Centre for Economic Data and Analysis, Ashoka University*
- Jan 2021 ○ Worked on processing large economic datasets including the Census, NFHS, and NSS using STATA and R to create summary statistics for a data portal aiming to make Indian economic data more easily accessible.
- Coordinated with five other interns for extensive data and UI testing.

## Skills

|                      |                                                                                          |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Stata<br>(Advanced)  | Cleaning, processing, and analysing data. Creating visualizations and regression tables. |
| R (Advanced)         | Scraping data, using geographical data and shapefiles, analysing/processing data.        |
| Python<br>(Advanced) | Processing and analysing data, GIS mapping, modelling and simulation, machine learning.  |
| Others               | SurveyCTO, Qualtrics, Julia (Basic), MATLAB (Basic)                                      |
| Writing              | Research papers, policy analysis, narrative non-fiction                                  |
| Languages            | English, Hindi, Punjabi                                                                  |

---

## Other Work Experience

- Jun 2024 – **Data Research Assistant, Dr. Feyaad Allie, Harvard Kennedy School**  
Oct 2024 ○ Part-time data-related assistance for Dr. Allie's research on political representation, including scraping government data, cleaning datasets, and preparing results.
- Oct 2021 – **Research Consultant, SEEDS India, Chennai, India**  
May 2022 ○ Created policy briefs and research reports combining secondary research with field data on the threat of climate disasters in Chennai for the Municipal Corporation, focusing on increased prevalence of flooding.
- Jan 2020 – **Research Associate, LeadCap Ventures, Delhi, India**  
Dec 2021 ○ Created policy-focused research reports by analysing primary data collected from surveys and interviews and combining those insights with extensive literature reviews. Worked on projects with Afghanistan's Government, Qatar Development Bank, Iraq's Ministry of Trade, and the Welingkar School of Business.
- Jul 2019 – **Intern (Public Policy), Chase India, Delhi, India**  
Aug 2019 ○ Worked on policy analysis for public and private stakeholders. Gave inputs on tourism policies, suggested amendments on a parliamentary Anti-Trafficking Bill, and analysed parliamentarians' stance on health policy.
- Jun 2019 – **Intern, Byju's/Career Labs, Bengaluru, India**  
Jul 2019 ○ Assisted the creation of a new skill-building and employability enhancement platform for graduate students.

---

## Other Projects

- Apr 2019 – **Campaign Assistant for 2019 Elections: Manish Tewari, Indian National Congress**  
May 2019 Carried out data analysis, surveys, and social media campaigns for a successful Lok Sabha campaign in Punjab.
- Group Research Project: South Asian Economics Students Meet**  
Studied the impacts of COVID-19 on micronutrient deficiency in South Asian countries, and the possible use of biofortified crops to tackle malnutrition. Presented at the SANEM International Development Conference, 2021.